

LIN7209 – Syntax

Subjects

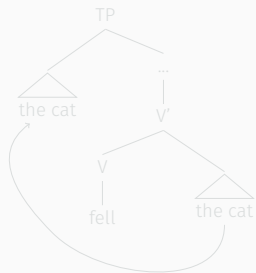
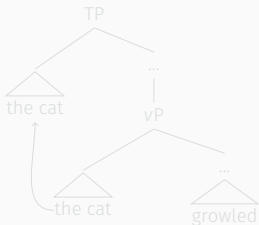
Adèle Hénot-Mortier (based on David's original materials)

11/11/2025

Queen Mary University of London

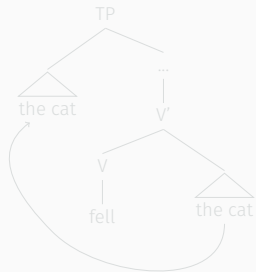
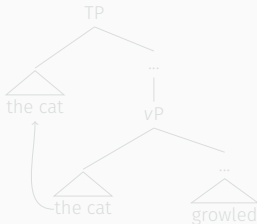
Refresher on subjects

- English finite Ts have an “**EPP**” property (for **E**xtended **P**rojection **P**rinciple), i.e. need their Spec filled with something overt.
- The subject of a sentence is then **whatever moves to Spec-TP**.
- Underlyingly, this subject may be born as:
 - an **external argument** (typically an AGENT in Spec-vP). This happens with transitive and unergative (e.g. *jump*, *growl*) verbs.
 - or an **internal argument** (typically THEME, in Comp-V). This happens with unaccusative (e.g. *arrive*, *fall*) verbs.



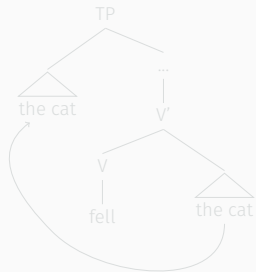
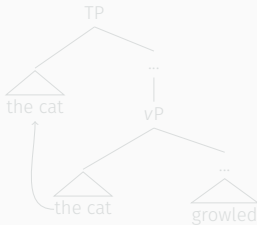
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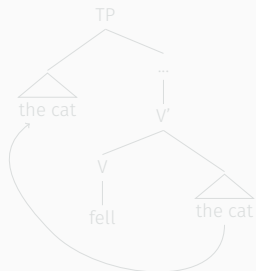
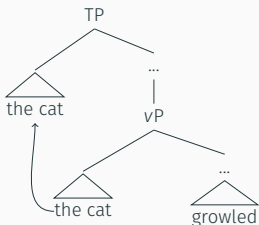
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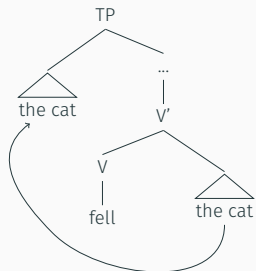
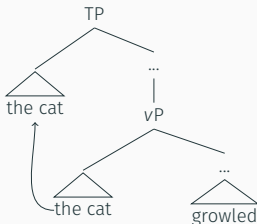
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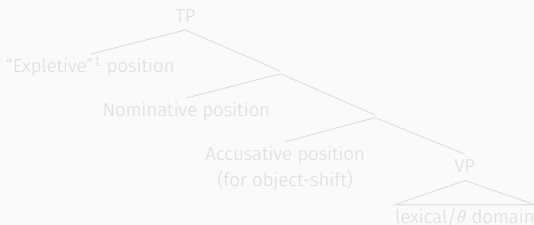
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Consequences

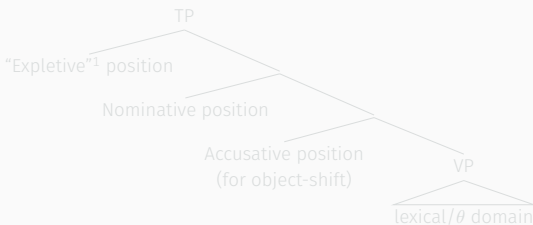
- To be a “subject” is to be in a specific **position** in relation to a specific **head**, e.g. T. **Structural** definition.
- When moving to the functional domain, subjects trigger **morphosyntactic processes**: agreement, case marking.
- McCloskey shows evidence from Irish that there is no single “subject position”, neither downstairs, nor upstairs; the various properties associated with the “subject” are **distributed** across a range of distinct syntactic positions.



¹“Expletive” means contentless. English *it/there* are usually treated as expletives. They are used to satisfy the EPP without adding any extra meaning to the sentence.

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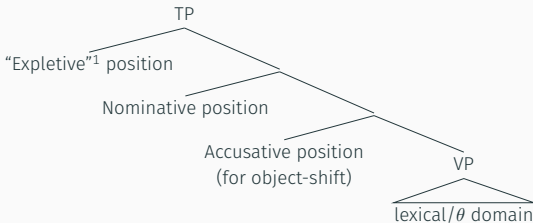
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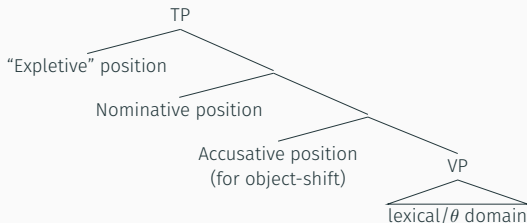
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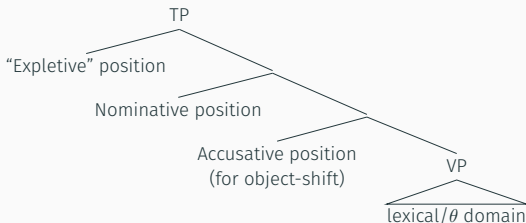
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Conceptual advantages



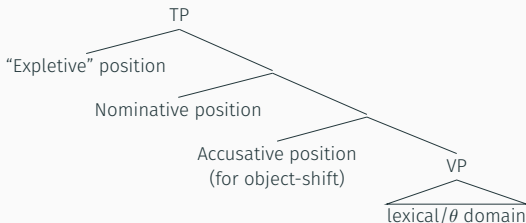
- Each “subject” position corresponds to a specific aspect of “subjecthood”: **obligatoriness**, distinctive **morphosyntax**, possible semantic **roles**. More modular.
- Better account of **cross-linguistic variation**: in some languages for instance, the “expletive position” may have strong requirements (i.e. must be filled), in other languages, it may not be the case.

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Lessons from Irish (at a glance)

- Irish unlike English **does not seem to have the EPP at all**: the “expletive” position is defective in that respect.
- Still, if VP contains one or more bare DP-arguments, then the most prominent of them *is* subject to a movement requirement, **slightly below T/Spec-TP**. McCloskey calls this case-assigning position the “Nominative” position.
- Lastly, Irish allows for Dative subjects in specific environments. These subjects are shown to be systematically **related to both the θ -domain and to the “expletive” position**, where they get their special case and can influence the distribution of the entire clause.

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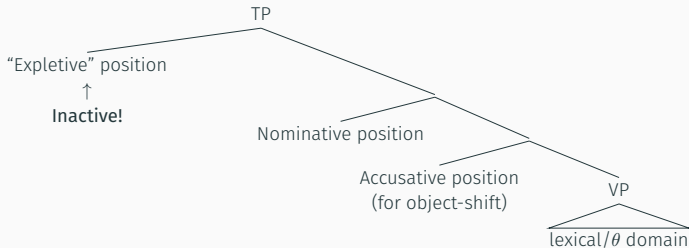
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Irish and the EPP

Irish is EPP-less

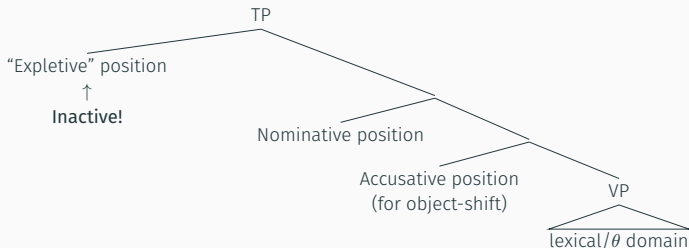
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- Irish is a strong VSO language.

(1) Do fuair sé nuachtán Meiriceánach'óna dheartháir
PAST got he newspaper American from-his brother
an lá cheana.
the-other-day
'He got an American paper from his brother the other day.'

- Any idea how to cash this out?

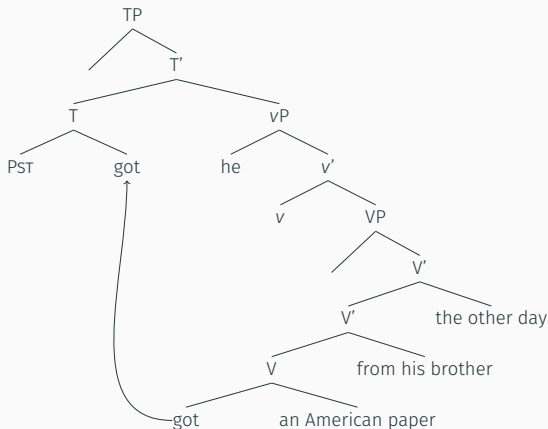
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Deriving VSO

- Idea: **subject doesn't move to Spec-TP (unlike English); verb moves to T (unlike English).**



- Let's proceed to the first more sophisticated argument: ellipsis.

Background on VP ellipsis

- Ellipsis is the rule-governed **omission of recoverable constituents** that are syntactically required in other contexts.
- (2) Ed plays soccer, but Al doesn't ~~play soccer~~.
- (3) a. Ed plays soccer, and Al does ~~play soccer~~ too.
b. Ed plays soccer, and Al ~~plays soccer~~ too.

Argument 1: Verb-stranding ellipsis

- In Irish, one can reply to a statement with a **single tensed verb**. This is called Verb-stranding VP ellipsis (**VSVPE**).

- (4) a. Thóg sí teach dófa ar an Mhullach Dubh.
raised she house for-them on the Mullaghduff
'She built a house for them in Mullaghduff.'
- b. A-r thóg?
INTERR-PAST raised
'Did she?'
- c. Creidim gu-r thóg.
I-believe C-PAST raised
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- VSVPE requires 2 ingredients: a **high-enough verb** (raised to the inflectional domain); and a **low-enough subject** (to be effectively deleted under ellipsis).
- Irish being VSO, with V-to-T movement, and no movement of the subject to Spec-TP, allows this.
- English, which does not move main verbs and moves its subject to Spec-TP, is correctly predicted to disallow VSVPE.

- (5) a. She built a house for them in Mullaghduff.
b. * Built?
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- Irish is not an isolated case! VSVPE has been argued to exist in Hebrew (Doron, 1991) Ndendeule (Bantu; Ngonyani, 1996), Japanese (Funakoshi, 2016), Bengali (Halder, 2022).

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(6) “Salient” Unaccusatives:

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(7) Impersonal passives:

go bhfuil trialtha chó maith agat
C is proved so good by-you
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- **No bare nominal**, only a PP!
- If T had an EPP feature, these sentences would be ungrammatical as PPs (or the DPs inside them) cannot be targeted by T.
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- In English certain predicates trigger the **movement of an embedded subject to a matrix position** (subject or object).

- (8) a. **Subject raising:** Jo seems [_{TP} $\varnothing$ to have won].
b. **Object raising:** Al predicted Jo [_{TP} $\varnothing$ to have won].

- This can be understood as follows: the non-finite embedded T cannot assign Case/agree with the embedded subject, so this subject **needs to raise to agree with the finite matrix T instead**.
- A diagnostic for subject raising² is the **expletive alternation**: a meaning similar to (8a) can be achieved by having *it* as matrix subject, in which case the embedded clause is tensed and its subject does not raise!

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- In Irish, subjects can also raise to the matrix, in which case they can display Nominative (NOM) case (if pronominal).

(10) Thaibhsigh siad di a bheith iompaithe dearg
appeared they.NOM to-her be [-FIN] turned red
'They seemed to her to have turned red.'

- Again, matrix VSO (and not SVO) word order suggests there's no EPP.
- Additionally, the presence of NOM indicates that **the EPP and Case are uncorrelated in Irish**, i.e. get checked/assigned in distinct positions.
- Specifically, a high "expletive" position deals with the EPP, and is inactive in the language, while a lower, NOM-assigning position, still assign Case to the raised subject.

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- Extra evidence that the EPP cannot be active; otherwise the embedded subject should have been attracted upstairs.

Argument 3 cont'd: Irish raising and agreement

- When Irish subject actually raise, the raising predicate (here, 'chance' meaning *happen*) agrees with the raised DP. Shows that **the EPP (not there) and agreement (there) are uncorrelated**.

(12) Do ráinís an uair sin a bheith i gContae an Chláir.
PST chance.2SG that time be [-FIN] in County Clare
'You happened at that time to be in County Clare.'

³Paróiste an Fheirtéaraigh, Tomás Mac Síthigh, Kerry

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(12) Do ráinís an uair sin a bheith i gContae an Chláir.
PST chance.2SG that time be [-FIN] in County Clare
'You happened at that time to be in County Clare.'

- What's going on here?

(13) ráinig an uair seo í a bheith i gContae an Chláir.
chanced this time her be [-FIN] in County Clare
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- When the subject is **low**, the matrix verb does not agree with it and instead take a **special "analytic" form**. Extra evidence that actual raising may not take place, and that there's no EPP.

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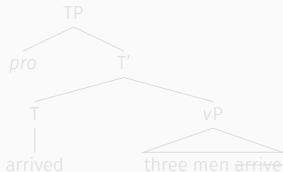
Is Irish really EPP-less?

- The fact that subjects don't move to Spec-TP strongly suggests Irish Ts don't have an EPP feature.
- Alternative explanation: maybe Irish has a low subject because another silent expletive (like a silent *there*) satisfies the EPP!

(14) There are three cats.

(15) a. There arrived three men.

b. Three men arrived.



If Irish had *pro* + an active EPP

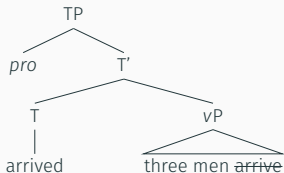
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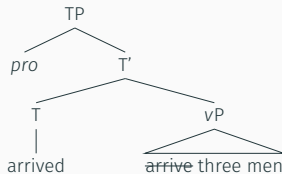
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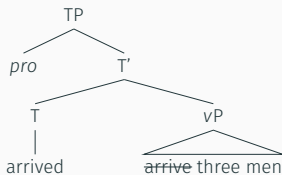
Issue with a “pro” approach to Irish



If Irish had *pro* + an active EPP

- Having an optional *pro* in Spec-TP predicts an **alternation** between VSO and SVO word orders: whenever *pro* is not there, the subject *must* hop over the verb because of the active EPP, yielding SVO. But **Irish is strictly VSO**, indicating that it is truly EPP-less.
- Additionally, languages with the EPP and a silent *pro* usually display **definiteness restrictions** in existential structures. We'll now see **Irish does not** (fourth and last argument).

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Existential constructions in English and French

(16) There are three men.

(17) (Il) y a trois hommes.
It there has three men.

- *There/y* move to Spec-TP to satisfy the EPP in English and French.⁴
- Moreover, existential constructions don't like definite THEMES, e.g. pronouns, proper names, definite descriptions, and certain quantifiers like *every* and *most*: it's the **definiteness restriction**.⁵

(18) * There is she/her/Sachou/the cat/every cats.

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Argument 4: Irish existential constructions

(19) Bhí an dara cogadh domhanda ann na blianta sin
was the second war global in-it those years
'There was the Second World War in those years.'⁶

(20) Tá tú ann.
be.PRES you in-it
'You exist./'There's you.'⁷

- *There (ann)* is low! Indicates that *ann* does not need to move to satisfy the EPP.⁸
- “Definite” elements are ok! If the definiteness constraint is syntactically driven, suggests the syntactic trigger (arguably the EPP) is not active in Irish.

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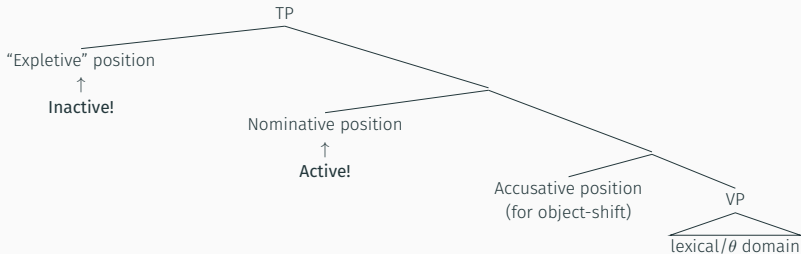
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Subject movement, still

Irish subject move to an intermediate case assigning position

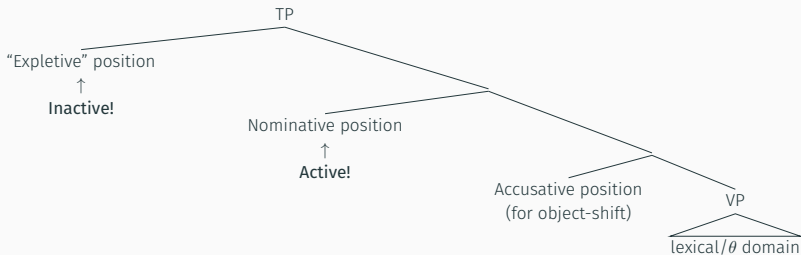
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- Two main arguments: positioning between subjects and **high adverbs**, and **quantifier stranding**.

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- Subjects are higher than high adverbs! Evidence that **they move after all, though not as high as Spec-TP** (the “expletive” position).

Argument 2: Quantifier stranding

- Irish quantified phrases (QPs) may **strand the quantifier** *all* (*uilig*) wherever they stop, **including in intermediate positions**. Think of them as the Little Thumbling.
- The possible positions of *uilig* thus mark the **successive positions of the subject QP** throughout the derivation. And **there are several of them!**



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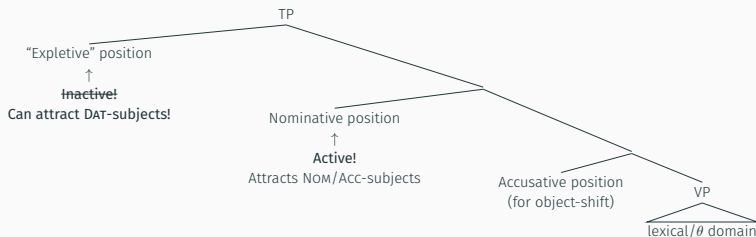
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Irish dative-marked subjects

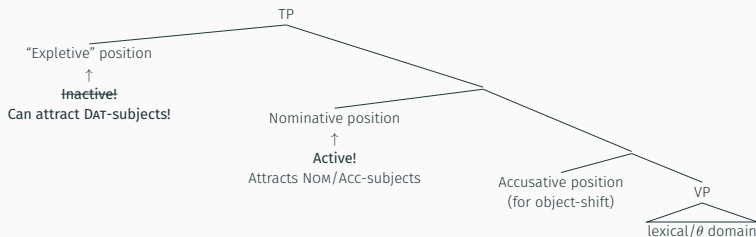
Dative marked subject exploit Spec-TP, after all

- The last third of the paper focuses on dative-marked subjects.
- Such subjects take a **variety of θ -roles** and forms, including expletives.
- Additionally, they tend to **determine the distribution of the entire clause** containing them, which means that they must end up at its edge.
- McCloskey takes this as evidence that such dative subjects originate in the θ -domain (below VP), and end up in Spec-TP, whether overtly or covertly, where they get their special case.



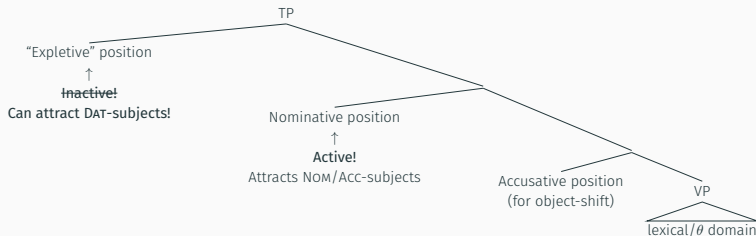
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Dative marked subjects

- Subjects of Irish nonfinite clauses may be marked by the **dative preposition** *do*.

(23) tar éis dó an abhainn a chur de
after **to-him** the river put [-FIN] of-him
'after he had put the river behind him.'¹⁰

- This is unusual, as dative tends to mark goals/indirect objects. Dative subjects can bear a **wide range of θ -roles** (see paper).
- This implies that DAT-subjects are attracted by a [+DAT] feature on a higher head incompatible with [+FIN]. This makes T a good candidate as it is specified for finiteness.
- This makes this dative case purely **structural**—it does not correlate with semantics and specifically what happened in the verbal domain.

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“Un-raised” DAT-subjects

- In formal varieties, DAT-subjects may appear lower, to the right of a shifted object and to the right of the infinitive. This seems to correspond to the **original θ -position**.

(26) Tar éis tig a thógáil dhóibh ar an mBuailtín
after house raise [-FIN] **to-them** in Ballyferriter
‘after they built a house in Ballyferriter.’

- Still, even in these “unraised” cases, the distribution of the entire clause is as restricted as in the raised cases.
- Idea: still movement to Spec-TP to get structural DAT, but covertly, after Spell-Out.
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